Product Track | ROUND 3

VALUE DESK

Turning accumulated Membership Rewards into personalized, actionable value plans

TEAM NAME: DALL-Eminators

PARTICIPANT NAME	EMAIL ID (Official)	INSTITUTE
Siddharth Goswami	siddharth.goswami@iiitb.ac.in	IIIT Bangalore
Nishant Khatri	nishant.khatri@iiitb.ac.in	IIIT Bangalore

Customers can see their rewards — but not what to do with them

One journey gap: value realization. Turning points, benefits and offers already earned into a clear, personal choice.

TODAY

01 EARN
Points and benefits build up over the year.

→

02 SEE BALANCE
The app shows a number.

→

03 SEE OPTIONS
Redemption is presented as a menu.

→

04 WORK IT OUT
Which option fits me? Some customers look outside Amex to decide (3rd-party forums etc.)

→

05 OUTCOME
Risk: an easy default, or no decision at all.

WITH VALUE DESK See what your points are worth to you → Compare a few realistic plans, or Hold → Choose → Complete it in the existing Amex flow

THE GAP Customers can see the value they have earned. What they cannot see is which option is right for them. Value Desk closes that gap.

SUPPORTING EVIDENCE

70%

of Indian cardholders were found not to fully optimise their rewards — attributed to fragmented information and a tedious redemption process.

Survey of 5,000+ cardholders across 9 cities (2025), commissioned by a rewards-optimisation platform. Directional, not independent.

₹1 = 4 pts

is the statement-credit adjustment rate in Amex India's Membership Rewards terms. Value per point varies by option, which is what makes the choice hard.

Amex India MR T&Cs — rate stated in the account-closure clause.

No expiry

Points keep accumulating without an expiry deadline, so customers can defer the decision.

Amex India MR T&Cs, Section IV.

WHY NOW Balances keep building with no expiry pressure, and Amex Travel's online booking portal in India was paused from 27 Jan 2026. Amex already has the data and the redemption infrastructure. The missing layer is helping the customer decide — and AI can now make that recommendation easy to understand, without giving AI control of the numbers or the transaction.

We start with customers holding valuable points they aren't using

Silent Accumulators. We can help them because Amex already holds everything a good recommendation needs.

SILENT ACCUMULATORS

- Premium cardmember in India
- Meaningful Membership Rewards points balance (≥ 50,000 points)
- Limited recent high-value redemption
- Sufficient card tenure / past first renewal

These thresholds are working assumptions. We would calibrate them against Amex portfolio data.

WHAT THEY NEED

Hypothesised needs. We test them in the manual pilot before we build.

- ☐ Know what my points are worth to me
- ☐ Get a clear recommendation, with the trade-off
- ☐ Decide without leaving the Amex app
- ☐ Be sure it is safe before I transfer

WHY AMEX IS WELL PLACED TO HELP

	Points balance	Spend context	Benefits & eligibility	Live offers	Redemption rails
Value Desk (inside Amex)	✓	✓	✓	✓	✓
Third-party platforms	*Partial*	*Partial*	—	—	—
Points blogs, forums, creators	—	—	—	—	—
Award-search / travel tools	—	—	—	—	—

✓ direct access Partial = only with the customer's permission, and not in real time — not available

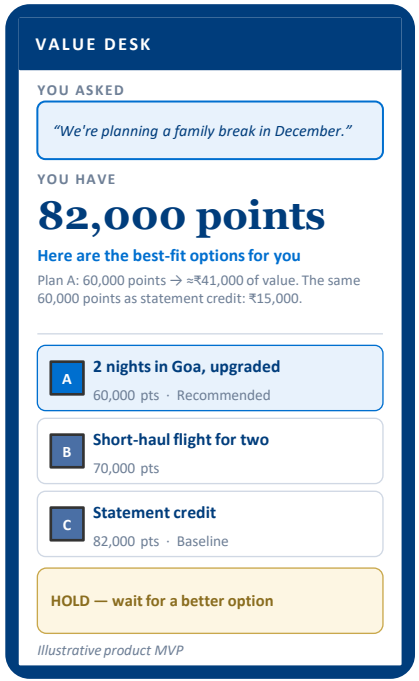
Amex can bring all five together in one place.
Others offer good general strategy, and some can see a balance with permission. Amex can also see what this customer is eligible for, which offers apply, and can complete the redemption. That combination is the advantage.

WHY TODAY'S AMEX SURFACES DON'T CLOSE IT

- The catalogue presents options. It does not rank them for this customer.
- Amex Offers help customers earn on future spend — a different job.
- Concierge is excellent for high-touch support, but cannot personally advise every eligible customer.
- The transfer flow assumes the customer already knows where they want to transfer.

Value Desk turns a points balance into a clear choice

The customer says what they need. Value Desk returns three realistic plans, one recommendation, and an honest "Hold".



WHAT THEY ASKED FOR	+	WHAT THEY HAVE	+	A BENEFIT NOT USED	+	AN OFFER THEY QUALIFY FOR	=	ONE CLEAR OUTCOME
"A family break in December"		60,000 points		Hotel programme status they already hold		Dining credit at the property		Two upgraded nights in Goa, with dining covered

WHAT EACH PLAN SHOWS THE CUSTOMER

PLAN A — RECOMMENDED

2 nights at a partner hotel in Goa, upgraded

60,000 pts · 22,000 left over

Why this, for you: matches your December break, and you have stayed at partner hotels twice recently.

Trade-off: transfer timing varies, and transferred points cannot be reversed.

PLAN B

Return short-haul flight for two via an airline partner

70,000 pts · 12,000 left over

Why this, for you: fits your December dates on a route you fly often, and your account is already linked.

Trade-off: award availability must be confirmed before you transfer.

PLAN C — BASELINE

Statement credit against your card account

82,000 pts · ₹20,500 (illustrative)

Why we show it: the honest floor, so every other plan can be judged against it.

Trade-off: instant and certain, but the lowest value of the three.

"HOLD" IS A REAL ANSWER When nothing clears the value threshold, Value Desk says so and tells the customer what to wait for. We would rather recommend waiting than push a redemption that isn't worth it.

WHY THIS IS PREMIUM Amex does the thinking, gives one clear recommendation with the trade-off named, and is willing to say "not yet". That is what premium should feel like.

Illustrative example. The ₹20,500 floor uses the ₹1 = 4 points adjustment rate stated in Amex India's Membership Rewards terms (account-closure clause) as a conservative reference. All other rupee figures are illustrative; in the live product every number is calculated from approved partner data.

Recommendations are calculated safely — AI only explains them

AI understands the request and explains the answer. The rules-based engine decides everything in between — it never does the maths and never moves points.

1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Customer asks	**Understand context**	**Find the options**	**Remove what doesn't fit**	**Compare and rank**	**Show the best few**	**AI explains**
In their own words. AI turns it into structured criteria.	Points, spend, benefits and offers they already have	Every redemption path open to them today	Not enough points, not linked, timing won't work	Value, fit to the need, effort, and Amex cost	Three plans — or Hold, if none is good enough	Puts the answer in plain language

→ **THE CUSTOMER COMPLETES IT IN THE EXISTING AMEX REDEMPTION FLOW.** We build no new transfer rails, and the customer always confirms the final action.

AI is used in two places only: to understand the request (step 1) and to explain the answer (step 7). Steps 2–6 are calculated by the rules-based engine.

HOW WE RANK PLANS

Customer value · Relevance · Feasibility · Friction Penalty · Amex cost

- Ranking on value per rupee of Amex cost is what keeps a high-value recommendation from becoming an expensive one.
- Effort matters too — a brilliant plan the customer never completes is worth nothing.

If no plan clears the statement-credit baseline by a set margin, the answer is Hold.

WHAT AI DOES — AND WHAT IT NEVER DOES

DOES

- Turns the customer's request into structured criteria
- Explains the recommendation in plain language
- Answers follow-up questions

NEVER

- Calculates a value or point total
- Invents a partner, rate or offer
- Decides eligibility
- Moves points or makes a transfer

HOW WE KEEP IT ACCURATE

01 — Numbers come from approved data
Every figure traces back to an approved source.

02 — AI can only use what it is given
It cannot state a fact the engine did not supply.

03 — Every number is checked
Any figure AI writes is verified against the source data.

04 — Eligibility is checked first
We never show a plan the customer cannot actually use.

05 — Nothing happens automatically
The customer confirms, and we test accuracy regularly.

Start small: one card, one segment, three redemption paths

We prove the value with a narrow MVP and a control group before we scale anything.

WHAT THE MVP INCLUDES

- India · one flagship premium card · the Silent Accumulator segment
- One surface: an entry point on the app home, and a Value Desk screen
- Three redemption paths: one hotel partner, one airline partner, statement credit
- Benefits and offers shown alongside · three plans · Hold · links into existing flows

WHAT WE DELIBERATELY LEAVE OUT

- Live award-seat search · automatic transfers or actions
- Household or multi-card point pooling · non-Amex rewards
- Financial advice of any kind · an open-ended chatbot
- Transfer-bonus timing — India bonus windows are infrequent

HOW WE RELEASE IT



TECHNICALLY FEASIBLE TODAY Existing Amex redemption rails + a governed rules engine + controlled AI. No new transfer infrastructure.

WHO OWNS IT A single Product Owner, accountable end to end, with a core team of Product, Engineering, Data, Partnerships and Legal.

WHAT WE NEED, AND FROM WHOM

Finance — approved cost-per-point data · Legal & Privacy — consent for personalization under India's DPDP framework · Partnerships — partner rates, minimums, account-linking · AI Governance — approval of the controlled AI pattern

WHAT COULD GO WRONG, AND OUR ANSWER

A transfer that can't be undone — eligibility checked first, no automatic transfers · AI states a wrong number — numbers come from approved data and are checked · Cost per point drifts up — Amex cost sits in the ranking and gates scaling · Reads as financial advice — information and decision support only, with Legal sign-off

We don't change the rewards — we improve how customers use them

No new points. No richer earn rates. A better recommendation, with Amex's cost kept inside the decision.

Rewards and benefits already earned
STARTING POINT

→

Turned into an outcome the customer chose
MEASURED IN PILOT

→

Customers report stronger perceived value for their annual fee
MEASURED BY SURVEY

→

More engagement with the app and the programme
MEASURED IN PILOT

→

Potentially stronger retention and lifetime value
HYPOTHESIS — TO BE TESTED

WHAT THIS LOOKS LIKE FOR ONE CUSTOMER

Illustrative only — the shape of the opportunity, not claimed Amex redemption values

Line	Value	Basis
Points held	82,000	*Illustrative*
If taken entirely as statement credit	₹20,500	*₹1 = 4 pts, Amex India MR terms*
Used on Plan A	60,000 pts → ₹41,000	*≈2.7× the statement-credit rate on the points used*
Points retained	22,000 → ₹5,500	*At the baseline rate*
Total value realized	**₹46,500**	
Extra value vs all-statement-credit	**₹26,000**	*From points already earned*
New points issued by Amex	None	*No change to earn rates*

HOW BIG THE PRIZE COULD BE — SIZING FUNNEL

	LOW	BASE	HIGH
Amex India cards outstanding — RBI	13 lakh	13 lakh	13 lakh
÷ cards per cardmember — assumption	1.5	1.3	1.2
× on the flagship premium card — assumption	8%	12%	18%
× past first renewal — assumption	60%	70%	80%
× meet all four criteria — assumption	20%	30%	40%
= Silent Accumulator segment	**~8,300**	**~25,000**	**~62,000**
× take-up of a recommendation — assumption	10%	20%	30%
= incremental customer value at stake	**₹2.2 cr**	**₹13.1 cr**	**₹48.7 cr**

Extra value per customer taken from the illustration at left (₹26,000). Only the first line is data; every other line is a stated assumption. Amex cost per point is calculated from internal Finance data and sits inside the ranking.

THE BUSINESS CASE, IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Value Desk does not increase reward generosity. It changes which redemption we recommend, while keeping Amex's cost inside the decision. Rewards still have a cost, so we keep that cost in the ranking and only scale recommendations that deliver customer value within Amex's economics. What we are after is a stronger customer response to rewards Amex already funds — measured in a controlled pilot, not assumed.

We measure customer value first — and scale only if the economics hold

One question per level. The primary answer arrives inside the pilot, not a year later.

PRIMARY — **Are customers turning more of their earned rewards into valuable outcomes?**

Incremental realized rewards value per customer, and incremental completion of the redemption types we define as high-value — against a control group, inside the pilot.

LEADING — **Do customers accept and act on what we recommend?**

Plan-to-action conversion · recommendation acceptance · time from recommendation to completed redemption

LAGGING — **Does this show up in the business over time?**

Renewal rate against control · spend per customer · lifetime value · survey: “I get good value for my annual fee”

GUARDRAILS — **Does quality stay high and cost stay in bounds?**

Weighted average cost per point · recommendation accuracy · complaints · servicing contacts about redemption

Lagging measures are hypotheses we test, not outcomes we claim.

HOW WE TEST IT

- Customers are randomly assigned to Value Desk or a control group, from the closed pilot onward.
- The primary answer is measured inside the pilot. We do not wait a renewal cycle to learn whether the product works.
- Indicative sizing: a 5pp lift on a 20% baseline needs roughly 1,000 customers per group. Final sizing depends on Amex's actual baseline.
- Renewal, spend and lifetime value are read at the next renewal cycle. They inform the next decision, not this one.

WHEN WE WOULD STOP — AGREED UP FRONT

- Customers do not act on the recommendations
- Cost per point moves outside the agreed guardrail
- Recommendation accuracy falls below the threshold
- Complaints or servicing contacts move the wrong way

→ **We stop and re-scope. We do not scale on a metric we hoped for.**

We will know this worked when a cardmember says: **“I get good value from my annual fee.”**